# Week 3: Space, Touch, Meta-communication and Listening

NPTEL Soft Skills · Prof. Binod Mishra · Lectures 11–15

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## Lecture 11: Proxemics

Week 3 · Course book PDF pages 168–179 (printed pages 167–178)

### Learning objectives

- Define proxemics and chronemics.
- State the four space zones with distances and who may enter each.
- Relate space and time to status, power and culture; distinguish high-context and low-context cultures.
- Recall examples and quotations from the lecture.

### Important definitions

**PROXEMICS**

The study of physical space in communication; from *proximity* (nearness). It is called relationship communication because it reflects behavioural norms.

**CHRONEMICS**

The study of time in communication: how time is perceived, used and valued across cultures and professions.

**AIR BUBBLE**

The personal space every human (and animal) needs around the body.

**LOW-CONTEXT CULTURE**

A culture that relies on written, explicit messages and attaches less importance to non-verbal cues.

**HIGH-CONTEXT CULTURE**

A culture that derives meaning from non-verbal cues and context and prefers short written messages.

## Core concepts

### Why space matters

- Space shows warmth, need for freedom, friendliness and power.
- Freed animals feel relaxed; humans too need breathing space.
- Violation of space makes people feel threatened.
- Mehrabian: “Status manifests itself by relaxed posture and ways of interacting.”

### Four space zones

1. **Intimate zone** – up to **18 inches**; family, close relatives, intimate people. Touch is allowed.
2. **Personal zone** – **18 inches to 4 feet**; friends, colleagues, peers.
3. **Social zone** – **4 to 12 feet**; strangers and occasional visitors such as plumbers, electricians, milkmen.
4. **Public zone** – **12 to 30 feet or more**; public speakers and leaders addressing audiences; feedback is hard to read.

Many Europeans keep 15–25 cm in the intimate zone. A person allowed one zone must not enter an inner zone.

### Space, status and power

- Bosses have large rooms or corner offices; employees have smaller cabins; furniture signals status.
- In the US non-verbal communication at work reinforces power; space denotes control and dominance.
- Going very close to a boss makes him feel threatened.

### Cultural examples

- **Japanese hosts** gave a US guest space by sitting with the driver in the front seat; the guest felt lonely and embarrassed. Later British students sat away from him: “you and I are close friends”.
- Arabs of the same sex stand closer than North Americans; Indians often stand close.
- A Danish couple violated American space at an American club.
- An American and a Japanese adjusted distances like dancing: the Japanese moved close and the American stepped back.
- A violation of space at a political rally led to a tragic incident.

### Low- versus high-context cultures

- **Low context:** North America, Germany, England, France, Italy, Scandinavia – put things in writing; ignore non-verbal cues; Americans write long emails.
- **High context:** Japan, China, Arab countries, Greece, Mexico, Spain – read non-verbal cues; write short messages.
- Americans may find the French withholding; the French may find Americans dominant.

### Chronemics

- Time is a **commodity**; punctuality earns respect and reveals personality and attitude.
- Missing deadlines suggests insincerity.
- Latin American and Mexican meetings may start late; the UK expects punctuality; India talks about time but is often late.
- **Robert E. Hall:** "Time talks and space speaks."
- Plan a presentation by time: do not let the introduction be long; give beginning, development and end proper time.
- Leaders decide how much time to give to whom; this shows the importance they give.
- Gather facts about the other culture's view of space and time to avoid miscommunication.

## Types, classifications and characteristics

### Space zones

| Zone | Distance | Who is allowed |
|---|---|---|
| Intimate | Up to 18 inches | Family, close relatives, intimates |
| Personal | 18 inches – 4 feet | Friends, colleagues, peers |
| Social | 4 – 12 feet | Strangers, occasional visitors, service people |
| Public | 12 – 30 feet or more | Public speakers, leaders, audiences |

## Theories, principles, models and contributors

**TIME TALKS AND SPACE SPEAKS — ROBERT E. HALL**

Time and space are non-verbal cues that communicate.

**STATUS AND POSTURE — MEHRABIAN**

"Status manifests itself by relaxed posture and ways of interacting."

## Examples and applications

**EXAMPLE**

Japanese escorts seated in front with the driver, leaving the US guest alone in the back.

**EXAMPLE**

Danish couple at an American club violating American space.

**EXAMPLE**

Latin American meetings starting late after chat; British punctuality.

## Comparison tables

### Low-context versus high-context cultures

| Point | Low context | High context |
|---|---|---|
| Examples | North America, Germany, England, France, Italy, Scandinavia | Japan, China, Arab countries, Greece, Mexico, Spain |
| Messages | Written, long, explicit | Short; rely on non-verbal cues |
| Non-verbal cues | Less importance | Great importance |

### Proxemics versus chronemics

| Proxemics | Chronemics |
|---|---|
| Space and distance | Time and punctuality |
| Four zones | Time as a commodity; timing of talk |
| ‘Space speaks’ | ‘Time talks’ |

## Important facts for MCQ revision

**EXAM TIP**

- Four zones: intimate (up to 18 in), personal (18 in–4 ft), social (4–12 ft), public (12–30 ft+).
- Proxemics derives from proximity.
- Robert E. Hall: Time talks and space speaks.
- Low-context: North America, Germany, England, France, Italy, Scandinavia.
- High-context: Japan, China, Arab countries, Greece, Mexico, Spain.
- Bosses occupy larger or corner spaces.
- Plumbers, electricians and milkmen belong in the social zone.
- Arabs stand closer than North Americans.
- Meetings in Latin America often begin late.

**QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)**

| Question | Quiz PDF page | Concept tested | Type |
|---|---|---|---|
| W3 Q1 | p.11 | Proxemics | MCQ |
| W3 Q4 | p.11 | Chronemics | MCQ |
| W3 Q6 | p.12 | Hall's proxemic zones | MCQ |
| W3 Q10 | p.12 | High-context and low-context cultures | MSQ |

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

## Summary

Proxemics studies how space communicates. Four zones – intimate (to 18 in), personal (to 4 ft), social (4–12 ft), public (12–30 ft+) – are linked to relationship and status, and vary with culture. High-context cultures read non-verbal cues while low-context cultures rely on written words. Chronemics treats time as a commodity; punctuality and timing show professionalism, and 'time talks and space speaks'.

## Practice questions

**Q1** (MCQ) The social zone extends from:

A. 0–18 inches

B. 18 inches–4 feet

C. 4–12 feet

D. 12–30 feet

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** Strangers and visitors are kept here.

**Q2** (MCQ) Who said 'Time talks and space speaks'?

A. Mehrabian

B. Robert E. Hall

C. Birdwhistell

D. Freud

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Hall is cited in the lecture.

**Q3** (MSQ) Which are high-context cultures?

A. Japan

B. China

C. Germany

D. Spain

> **Answer:** A, B, D
> **Why:** Germany is low context.

**Q4** (T/F) Colleagues and peers belong to the personal zone.

> **Answer:** True
> **Why:** Friends, colleagues and peers enter the personal zone.

**Q5** (Fill) The word proxemics comes from _____.

> **Answer:** proximity
> **Why:** Meaning nearness.

**Q6** Short How does office space show status?

> **Answer:** Bosses have larger, corner rooms; lower employees have smaller cabins.
> **Why:** Space denotes power and control.

## Revision checklist

☐ I know the four zones and distances.
☐ I can say who enters each zone.
☐ I can classify cultures by context.
☐ I can explain chronemics and cite Hall.
☐ I remember the Japanese car example.

# Lecture 12: Haptics: The Language of Touch

Week 3 · Course book PDF pages 180–192 (printed pages 179–191)

## Learning objectives

- Define haptics and its Greek origin.
- Explain meanings of touch: reassurance, warmth, regard, blessing, and how they vary by culture and setting.
- Describe types of handshakes (dominant, submissive, equal, dead fish, glove) and palm/finger gestures.
- Use cultural examples: Thailand, Spain, New Zealand hongi, India, Japan.

## Important definitions

**HAPTICS**

The systematic study of touch behaviour in communication; from a Greek word meaning ‘I touch’.

**DEAD FISH HANDSHAKE**

A limp, lifeless handshake showing lack of enthusiasm or encouragement; it may signal that a deal or negotiation will not go well.

**DOMINANT HANDSHAKE**

A handshake where one party takes control by pressing the other’s hand (palm on top) or gripping only the fingers; shows power.

**SUBMISSIVE HANDSHAKE**

A handshake in which one offers an open hand with the palm up, giving control to the other.

**HONGI**

A New Zealand greeting in which two people touch noses, treated as sharing breath.

**ENUMERATIVE AND LOCATIVE GESTURES**

Gestures that count points or point to locate an object.

## Core concepts

### Meanings of touch

- Touch generates feelings: warmth, friendliness, regard, togetherness, affection, reassurance (mother and child).

- In professional settings it may have a negative impact; a pat on the back may encourage a younger person but may be unwelcome from a stranger.
- Touching elders' feet in India shows regard and brings blessings.
- Greetings: hugging, folding hands (*namaste*), kissing the forehead (Latin America), handshakes.
- Mulk Raj Anand's *Untouchable*: the protagonist Bakha announces "an untouchable is coming" — touch once reflected class and caste.

**Cultural differences**

- **India:** handshake or folded hands; restrictions between men and women.
- **US and UK:** handshake is the commonest form; it troubles Indian women unused to shaking hands with the opposite sex.
- **Spain:** a handshake should last at least **seven strokes**; withdrawing may be seen as rejection.
- **Arab and Asian countries:** handshakes restricted.
- **Thailand and Laos:** touching a child on the head is rude because the head is sacred and holds the spirit.
- **Japan:** a woman covers her mouth while smiling; public display of feelings is impolite. Germans smile less.
- **New Zealand:** hongi.
- A senior's pat on a female junior's back and a forehead kiss led to debates and a court case.
- Advice: when unsure of local culture, **restrict touch**.

**Handshake types**

- **Dominant:** hand on top, palm down, or gripping only the fingers; used by those in higher positions.
- **Submissive:** palm up, giving control.
- **Equal:** hands meet in a shake of equality between peers.
- **Dead fish:** lifeless, discouraging.
- **Glove / politician's:** clasping with both hands; friendly show with a hidden meaning.
- Timing (beginning or end) also carries meaning.

**Palms and fingers**

- Flat hands may show depression or nothingness.
- Open palm = submission; palm on top of another's hand = dominance.
- Pointing or raising a finger = aggression and is often unwelcome.
- Finger-thumb circle = 'OK' but may be insulting in some cultures.

**Verbal and non-verbal congruence**

If a positive verbal message is accompanied by a negative non-verbal cue, there is conflict and the deal may fail. When verbal and non-verbal behaviour blend, the message is positive. Give others more room and respect their cultures.

## Types, classifications and characteristics

### Handshake types

| Type | Features | Message |
|---|---|---|
| Dominant | Hand on top; palm down; fingers only | Control and power |
| Submissive | Palm up; open hand | Giving control |
| Equal | Hands meet equally | Equality between peers |
| Dead fish | Limp and lifeless | Lack of interest; poor deal |
| Glove (politician) | Both hands clasp | Cheerful, friendly show |

## Examples and applications

**EXAMPLE**

Bakha in Mulk Raj Anand's *Untouchable* warns others of his approach.

**EXAMPLE**

Thailand: touching a child's head is rude.

**EXAMPLE**

Spain: seven-stroke handshake.

**EXAMPLE**

New Zealand: hongi, touching noses.

**EXAMPLE**

Japanese woman covers her mouth when smiling.

## Comparison tables

**Touch customs across cultures**

| Place | Practice / meaning |
|---|---|
| India | Folded hands; touching elders' feet gives respect and brings blessings |
| US/UK | Handshake is the common greeting |
| Spain | Handshake lasts about seven strokes |
| Thailand/Laos | Do not touch a child's head |
| New Zealand | Hongi nose greeting |
| Latin America | Kissing forehead |

## Important facts for MCQ revision

**EXAM TIP**

- Haptics comes from a Greek word meaning 'I touch'.
- Mulk Raj Anand wrote *Untouchable*; the protagonist is Bakha.
- In Spain a handshake should last at least seven strokes.
- In Thailand and Laos touching a child's head is rude because the head is sacred.
- Hongi is the New Zealand nose-touching greeting.
- Three handshake types: dominant, submissive and equal; also dead fish and glove.
- Raised or pointed fingers are aggressive.
- If verbal and non-verbal cues conflict, trust the non-verbal.
- Restrict touch when unfamiliar with the local culture.

**QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)**

| Question | Quiz PDF page | Concept tested | Type |
|---|---|---|---|
| W3 Q2 | p.11 | Haptics | MCQ |
| W3 Q8 | p.12 | Cultural meanings of touch | MCQ |

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

## Summary

Haptics is the language of touch and it varies by culture, gender and setting. Handshakes may express dominance, submission or equality; a dead-fish shake signals disinterest. Gestures with palms and fingers also carry meaning. Because touch can be misread (Thailand's head taboo, Spanish seven-stroke handshakes), professionals should learn local norms, restrict touch when unsure and ensure verbal and non-verbal messages agree.

## Practice questions

**Q1** (MCQ) The word haptics comes from a Greek word meaning:

A. I see

B. I touch

C. I speak

D. I move

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Haptics studies touch.

**Q2** (MCQ) Touching a child's head is considered rude in:

A. Spain

B. New Zealand

C. Thailand and Laos

D. Japan

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** The head is regarded as the seat of the spirit.

**Q3** (MSQ) Which are handshake types discussed?

A. Dominant

B. Submissive

C. Equal

D. Dead fish

> **Answer:** A, B, C, D
> **Why:** All appear in the lecture.

**Q4** (T/F) In Spain a handshake should last about seven strokes.

> **Answer:** True
> **Why:** Pulling away earlier may signal rejection.

**Q5** (Fill) The New Zealand nose-touching greeting is _____.

> **Answer:** hongi
> **Why:** It symbolises sharing breath.

**Q6** (Short) What should a person do when unsure of another culture's touch norms?

> **Answer:** Restrict touch behaviour and respect local customs.
> **Why:** Good intentions can be misread.

## Revision checklist

☐ I know the origin of haptics.
☐ I can describe each handshake type.
☐ I recall cultural examples (Thailand, Spain, NZ, India, Japan).
☐ I know Anand's *Untouchable* and Bakha.
☐ I can explain verbal–non-verbal conflict.

# Lecture 13: Meta-communication

Week 3 · Course book PDF pages 193–208 (printed pages 192–207)

## Learning objectives

- Define meta-communication (meta = beyond) and explain implied meaning.
- Show how word choice, tone and positioning change meaning.
- Explain the uses and advantages of silence and pauses and the disadvantages of non-words (vocalised pauses).
- Distinguish pauses from silence and recall the quotations (Adrienne Rich, Kennedy).

## Important definitions

**META-COMMUNICATION**

Communication beyond words (meta = beyond): the implied meaning carried by choice of words, tone, hesitation, silence and context. It may be intentional or unintentional.

**NON-WORDS**

Fumbling for words and vocalised pauses (I mean, O.K., ah, um) that mar the flow of speech and suggest doubt or ambiguity.

**VOCALISED PAUSE**

A filler sound or phrase used when one lacks words.

**PAUSE**

A short break in speech that separates units of thought; a longer pause becomes silence.

**SHARED ASSUMPTIONS**

Common understanding on which successful communication depends, together with unspoken arguments.

## Core concepts

### What meta-communication includes

- Choice of words and why a speaker chooses them in a context.
- Tone of voice, temper and pitch.
- Hesitation, fumbling, breaks and silence.
- Implied meaning: ‘You are looking smart today’ may be praise or sarcasm depending on tone.
- It may be **unintentional**.

### Positioning of words

- The same words, differently broken, change meaning: **“Leave him, not kill him”** versus **“Leave him not, kill him”**.
- “Try to reach the venue well in time” may be advice, anxiety or good wishes.
- A question like “Would you mind having a cup of coffee with me?” is a polite request.

### Silence in meta-communication

- Silence can mean neutrality, impartiality, hiding feelings, non-participation, disagreement, dissonance or disinterest.
- A boss’s silence can be positive or negative: you must read non-verbal cues.
- Meaning varies across cultures. Silence can be loud, frightening or rewarding.
- Success in communication comes from shared assumptions and unspoken arguments.
- **Adrienne Rich:** “Lying is done with words and also with silence.”

### Advantages of silence

- Relieves monotony and gives the audience time to digest and revise.
- Gives the speaker time to think; **ignites thoughts**.
- Draws back an inattentive listener.
- Shows consideration; listeners love speakers who place silence among words.
- Helps coherence and connection.

### Non-words and their harm

- Fast speakers use vocalised pauses (I mean, O.K., ah, um) which mar the flow and signal doubt, ambiguity or lack of preparation.
- Fast delivery removes space between clauses and phrases; respect for the speaker falls.
- Better to be silent than to produce confused noises. Distinguish **providing silence** from **becoming silent**.
- Lengthy silence is disliked; keep it regulated.
- Written speeches use punctuation to place pauses (comma, semicolon, full stop, dash).
- The lecture mentions a delivery rate of 125–130 words per minute (earlier, 140–150).

### Pauses

- Brief breaks that divide thoughts, build rapport and goodwill, gain control and feedback.
- Listeners’ minds move faster than words; pauses let them analyse and digest.
- Only a confident, well-prepared speaker uses pauses well; actors are trained in them.
- Opening: assert presence by looking at the audience in silence — a mutual, unspoken agreement.
- Example: Kennedy’s “Ask not what your country can do for you — ask what you can do for your country” is effective because of the pause.

## Types, classifications and characteristics

**Uses of silence**

| Use | Effect |
|---|---|
| Neutrality / hiding reaction | Avoids revealing opinion |
| Non-participation / disagreement | Signals dissonance |
| Relief from monotony | Audience digests ideas |
| Time to think | Speaker generates new ideas |
| Attention | Draws in distracted listeners |

## Theories, principles, models and contributors

**LYING WITH SILENCE — ADRIENNE RICH**

"Lying is done with words and also with silence."

**PAUSE IN SPEECH — JOHN F. KENNEDY (QUOTED)**

The famous line gains force from a pause.

## Examples and applications

**EXAMPLE**

"Leave him, not kill him" versus "Leave him not, kill him".

**EXAMPLE**

A friend saying "You are looking damn smart today" may imply you earlier dressed badly.

**EXAMPLE**

A boss who stays silent on your request.

**EXAMPLE**

A meeting member silent to remain neutral.

## Comparison tables

**Pause versus silence versus non-words**

| Pause | Silence | Non-words |
|---|---|---|
| Short break dividing thoughts | Longer break with meaning | Fumbling, ah/um, I mean |
| Confident and planned | Intentional or obligatory | Signals doubt and poor preparation |
| Improves clarity | Can relieve, reflect or hide | Mars flow of speech |

## Important facts for MCQ revision

**EXAM TIP**

- Meta means beyond.
- Meta-communication may be unintentional.
- ‘Leave him, not kill him’ example shows the effect of word positioning.
- Silence can hide meaning or show disagreement.
- Non-words include ah, um, ‘I mean’, O.K.
- Adrienne Rich: lying is done with words and also with silence.
- Pauses are short breaks; longer breaks become silence.
- Silence ignites thoughts and relieves monotony.
- Kennedy’s sentence works because of its pause.

**QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)**

| Question | Quiz PDF page | Concept tested | Type |
|---|---|---|---|
| W3 Q3 | p.11 | Meta-communication | MCQ |
| W3 Q9 | p.12 | Silence as communication | MCQ |
| W3 Q13 | p.13 | Silence and pauses in speech | MSQ |
| W3 Q14 | p.13 | Non-words and vocalised pauses | MSQ |

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

## Summary

Meta-communication is communication beyond words: choice of words, tone, positioning, hesitation and silence. Silence and pauses relieve monotony, give time to think, build rapport and add emphasis, while non-words (ah, um, I mean) harm clarity and show poor preparation. Speakers should provide silence deliberately, keep it short and read others’ silences in context and culture.

## Practice questions

**Q1** (MCQ) ‘Meta’ in meta-communication means:

A. Before

B. Beyond

C. Below

D. Between

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** It is communication beyond words.

**Q2** (MCQ) ‘Lying is done with words and also with silence’ was said by:

A. Mark Twain

B. Pythagoras

C. Adrienne Rich

D. Dale Carnegie

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** Quoted in the lecture.

**Q3** (MSQ) Which are non-words?

A. Ah

B. Um

C. I mean

D. A planned pause

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** A planned pause is useful.

**Q4** (T/F) Meta-communication is always intentional.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** It may be unintentional.

**Q5** (Fill) A longer pause becomes _____.

> **Answer:** silence
> **Why:** Pauses are small breaks.

**Q6** (Short) State two advantages of silence for a speaker.

> **Answer:** It gives time to think and ignites new thoughts; it relieves monotony and wins attention.
> **Why:** It also helps coherence.

## Revision checklist

☐ I can define meta-communication.
☐ I can show how word positioning changes meaning.
☐ I can list advantages of silence.
☐ I know why non-words harm a speech.
☐ I can distinguish pause and silence.

# Lecture 14: Listening Skills

Week 3 · Course book PDF pages 209–225 (printed pages 208–224)

## Learning objectives

- Distinguish hearing from listening.
- List the stages of the listening process: hearing, filtering, interpreting, responding, remembering.
- Explain perceptive listening (Ernest D. Nathan) and the advantages of listening.
- Identify barriers: prejudging, ambiguity, bias/illusion, rigidity, premature evaluation.

## Important definitions

**LISTENING**

A conscious, mental skill and art of paying attention, understanding and remembering what is said; involves ears and brain together.

**HEARING**

A physiological activity requiring no extra effort; sound reaches the ear without conscious attention.

**PERCEPTIVE LISTENING**

Ernest D. Nathan: a conscious cognitive effort involving primarily the sense of hearing reinforced by other senses, leading to understanding and inspired by a sincere desire to understand.

**PREJUDGING**

Forming an opinion before listening completely; a barrier to listening.

**RIGIDITY**

Unwillingness to change one's view, which blocks listening (e.g. old-timers resisting the paperless office).

## Core concepts

### Listening versus hearing

- Hearing is physiological; listening is mental and needs conscious participation.
- Examples: radio playing while solving sums (hearing); remembering grandparents' stories (listening).
- Researchers: **60 to 75 percent** of time is spent in listening, yet we are not trained to listen.
- People listen to what interests them.
- Listening and hearing: "You never listen" means you do not pay attention.

### Process of listening

**Hearing → Filtering → Interpreting → Responding → Remembering.**

- Hearing: physical; make it mental.
- Filtering: words, expressions, idioms; unknown words block listening.
- Interpreting: understanding the message (e.g. a GM's instruction passed through channels).
- Responding: decision or reply; impossible without interpreting.
- Remembering: retaining data and quotations.

### Advantages of listening

- **Knowledge:** a means of gathering information; saves time and money (lectures instead of buying books).
- **Learning new things** and inspiring creativity and sharing.
- **Sound relationships** (parents, friends, colleagues).
- **Better performance:** follow the boss's instructions and colleagues' ideas; helps solve problems.
- **Vocabulary and pronunciation:** hearing words in context with tone and pronunciation.
- Avoids miscommunication; helps in exams through remembered lectures.
- Supports a paperless office.

### Barriers to listening

1. **Prejudging** – drawing conclusions early.
2. **Ambiguity** – unclear speaker or content.
3. **Bias or illusion** – 'I already know this subject'.
4. **Rigidity** – refusing change (demonetisation and paperless office examples).
5. **Premature evaluation** – judging the speaker by appearance.
6. Unfamiliar words; lack of interest; distractions (music while driving).

### How to listen well

- Follow "**SLANT**": Sit up, Listen, interpret and then think (as phrased in the lecture).
- Hear adequately; filter, interpret, respond, remember.
- Solve the problems affecting your listening.
- Respect the speaker's experience; judge thoughts, not appearance.
- Be patient: "patience not only pays, patience prevails."

## Types, classifications and characteristics

**Stages of the listening process**

| Stage | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Hearing | Physiological reception of sound |
| Filtering | Sorting words and expressions mentally |
| Interpreting | Understanding and relating meaning |
| Responding | Reacting, deciding or replying |
| Remembering | Retaining the information |

## Theories, principles, models and contributors

**PERCEPTIVE LISTENING — ERNEST D. NATHAN**

A conscious cognitive effort, involving mainly hearing reinforced by other senses, leading to understanding and inspired by a sincere desire to understand.

## Examples and applications

**EXAMPLE**

Radio plays while a student solves sums: hearing, not listening.

**EXAMPLE**

Remembering grandparents' stories because of intent listening.

**EXAMPLE**

A train-journey friendship built through listening.

**EXAMPLE**

Listening to music while driving can cause accidents.

**EXAMPLE**

Demonetisation and the paperless office as instances of rigidity.

## Comparison tables

### Hearing versus listening

| Point | Hearing | Listening |
|---|---|---|
| Nature | Physiological | Mental, conscious |
| Effort | No extra effort | Needs attention and purpose |
| Involvement | Only ears | Ears and brain |
| Retention | Often forgotten | Remembered |

## Important facts for MCQ revision

**EXAM TIP**

- Listening process: hearing, filtering, interpreting, responding, remembering.
- 60–75% of time is spent in listening.
- Hearing is physiological; listening is mental.
- Ernest D. Nathan defined perceptive listening.
- Barriers: prejudging, ambiguity, bias, rigidity, premature evaluation.
- Listening builds knowledge, relationships and vocabulary.
- Perceptive listening is inspired by a sincere desire to understand.
- SLANT: sit up, listen, interpret, think (as given in lecture).

**QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)**

| Question | Quiz PDF page | Concept tested | Type |
|---|---|---|---|
| W1 Q1 | p.3 | Hearing vs listening | MCQ |
| W3 Q5 | p.11 | Hearing vs listening | Fill-in-the-blank |

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

## Summary

Listening is a conscious mental skill, unlike hearing. It passes through hearing, filtering, interpreting, responding and remembering. Perceptive listening, as defined by Ernest D. Nathan, needs a sincere desire to understand. Listening brings knowledge, relationships, better performance and vocabulary, but prejudging, ambiguity, bias, rigidity and premature evaluation block it.

## Practice questions

**Q1** (MCQ) Which stage comes immediately after filtering in listening?

A. Hearing

B. Interpreting

C. Responding

D. Remembering

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Order: hearing, filtering, interpreting, responding, remembering.

**Q2** (MCQ) Perceptive listening was defined by:

A. Freud

B. Ernest D. Nathan

C. Adler

D. Mehrabian

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** It requires a sincere desire to understand.

**Q3** (MSQ) Which are barriers to listening?

A. Prejudging

B. Ambiguity

C. Rigidity

D. Sincere desire to understand

> **Answer:** A, B, C
> **Why:** A sincere desire promotes listening.

**Q4** (T/F) Hearing requires conscious effort just like listening.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** Hearing is physiological and needs no extra effort.

**Q5** (Fill) Researchers say _____ to 75 percent of time is spent listening.

> **Answer:** 60
> **Why:** Yet we are not trained to listen.

**Q6** (Short) Give two advantages of listening.

> **Answer:** It is a means of gaining knowledge and it builds sound relationships; also improves vocabulary and performance.
> **Why:** Listening saves time and money compared with reading alone.

## Revision checklist

☐ I can distinguish hearing and listening.
☐ I can list the five stages in order.
☐ I can define perceptive listening.
☐ I know the advantages and barriers.
☐ I remember 60–75% and SLANT.

# Lecture 15: Types of Listening

Week 3 · Course book PDF pages 226–239 (printed pages 225–238)

## Learning objectives

- Name and explain the three basic types of listening: combative, attentive, reflective.
- Explain content, empathetic, appreciative and analytical listening with uses.
- Identify external and internal factors affecting listening and prejudiced listening.
- Apply tips for effective listening and recall Hemingway's quotation.

## Important definitions

**COMBATIVE LISTENING**

Listening with protest or opposition in mind; the element of protest damages the listening process.

**ATTENTIVE LISTENING**

Paying equal attention to every word throughout, without analysing or interpreting in the process.

**REFLECTIVE LISTENING**

The most important form: listening and analysing in order to relate and gain knowledge.

**CONTENT LISTENING**

Listening carefully to bosses, leaders or chairpersons, often to take notes, so that instructions can be passed on or acted on.

**EMPATHETIC LISTENING**

Listening to a person's problem to share feelings, relieve stress and perhaps advise, so that the person feels motivated.

**APPRECIATIVE LISTENING**

Listening to ideas, performance or achievements and appreciating them.

**ANALYTICAL LISTENING**

Listening to all parties (e.g. in a dispute) and analysing before deciding.

## Core concepts

### Three basic types

1. **Combative** – listen to protest.

2. **Attentive** – listen to every word.
3. **Reflective** – listen and analyse; the most important.

**Types in the workplace**

- **Content** – meetings, new policies, instructions (upward and downward flow).
- **Empathetic** – employees with stress or personal crisis; boss listens, shares and advises.
- **Appreciative** – new ideas, papers, songs, policies need an appreciative audience.
- **Analytical** – listen to both parties in a dispute or while negotiating or inviting bids.

Use the right type for the purpose; analysing a person who only wants to unburden is wrong.

**Prejudiced listening**

- When something opposes our deeply rooted prejudices, the brain becomes over-stimulated and stops listening.
- We mentally plan a rebuttal or a question designed to embarrass the speaker.
- Criticism about colour, dress or a 'hasty argument' may block the listener.

**Situations needing listening**

- **Conversation** — good conversation needs patience in listening.
- **Group discussion** — listening makes a leader; even an idea-less member can contribute by listening.
- **Organisational activities** — coordination depends on listening.
- **Negotiation** — weigh pros and cons.
- **Interview** — do not jump to answer before the question is complete.
- **Meetings** — avoid whispering and parallel talk.

**Factors affecting listening**

- **External:** noise, venue, time, culture (hence schools in isolated places).
- **Internal:** state of mind (preoccupation), **ego** ("incurable disease"), language barriers/unknown words, different perceptions, ego clashes, rigid categories, ambiguity.

**Tips for effective listening**

- Be generous and go with an open mind.
- Concentrate on the speaker; judge thoughts, not appearance.
- Take brief notes while listening and summarise mentally.
- Do not interrupt; note doubts and ask politely afterwards.
- Show interest non-verbally; keep critical thinking to yourself.
- Avoid parallel talk; read the speaker's non-verbal cues, pauses and silences.
- Use gaps to relate ideas. Listen to learn and to unlearn.
- **Hemingway:** "I like to listen. I have learned a great deal from listening carefully. Most people never listen."

## Types, classifications and characteristics

### Types of listening by purpose

| Type | Purpose | Typical situation |
|---|---|---|
| Content | Gather information / instructions | Boss's announcement, meeting |
| Empathetic | Share feeling; relieve stress | Employee with personal problem |
| Appreciative | Acknowledge and enjoy | New idea, paper, song |
| Analytical | Evaluate and decide | Dispute, negotiation, bids |

### Basic three types

| Type | Key feature |
|---|---|
| Combative | Listening with protest |
| Attentive | Attention to every word |
| Reflective | Listening plus analysis; most important |

## Theories, principles, models and contributors

**LISTENING QUOTATION — ERNEST HEMINGWAY**

"I like to listen. I have learned a great deal from listening carefully. Most people never listen."

## Examples and applications

**EXAMPLE**

A boss criticises a project as 'hasty' and the author stops listening.

**EXAMPLE**

An over-excited interviewee answers before the question ends.

**EXAMPLE**

Educational institutions are located away from noise.

**EXAMPLE**

A manager listens empathetically to an employee's crisis.

## Comparison tables

**External versus internal factors**

| External | Internal |
|---|---|
| Noise | State of mind |
| Venue | Ego |
| Time | Language and perceptions |
| Culture | Ambiguity, rigidity, clashes |

## Important facts for MCQ revision

**EXAM TIP**

- Three basic types: combative, attentive, reflective.
- Reflective listening is the most important.
- Types by purpose: content, empathetic, appreciative, analytical.
- External factors: noise, venue, time, culture.
- Internal factors: state of mind, ego, language, perception.
- Do not interrupt, whisper or hold parallel talks in meetings.
- Take notes while listening.
- Hemingway quote: most people never listen.

**QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)**

| Question | Quiz PDF page | Concept tested | Type |
|---|---|---|---|
| W3 Q7 | p.12 | Types of listening | MCQ |
| W3 Q11 | p.13 | Factors affecting listening | MSQ |
| W3 Q12 | p.13 | Barriers to listening | MSQ |
| W3 Q15 | p.13 | Types of listening | Match the columns |
| W5 Q7 | p.20 | Combative listening | MCQ |

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

## Summary

Listening may be combative, attentive or reflective, with reflective listening the most valuable. In organisations content, empathetic, appreciative and analytical listening serve different purposes. Prejudice, noise, ego, preoccupation and language hamper listening, whereas an open mind, concentration, note-taking, patience and attention to non-verbal cues improve it.

## Practice questions

**Q1** (MCQ) The most important of the three basic types of listening is:

A. Combative

B. Attentive

C. Reflective

D. Appreciative

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** It involves analysis and relating.

**Q2** (MCQ) Listening to both parties in a dispute is:

A. Empathetic

B. Analytical

C. Appreciative

D. Content

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Analysis is needed before deciding.

**Q3** (MSQ) Select internal factors affecting listening.

A. Ego

B. State of mind

C. Noise

D. Language

> **Answer:** A, B, D
> **Why:** Noise is external.

**Q4** (T/F) In a meeting, parallel conversations help listening.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** They destroy the atmosphere of listening.

**Q5** (Fill) Listening to an employee's personal problem to relieve stress is _____ listening.

> **Answer:** empathetic
> **Why:** It may include advice.

**Q6** (Short) Suggest two tips for effective listening.

> **Answer:** Concentrate on the speaker with an open mind and take notes without interrupting.
> **Why:** Avoid prejudging and parallel talk.

## Revision checklist

☐ I know the three basic types.
☐ I can match the four purpose-based types to situations.
☐ I can list external and internal barriers.
☐ I know tips and the Hemingway quote.
☐ I understand prejudiced listening.